ETCSL 5.3.5 — The debate between Bird and Fish

- **Editors:** ETCSL project (J. Black, G. Cunningham, E. Robson, G. Zólyomi et al.), Oxford 1998–2006; composite after Vanstiphout and Alster (electronic source 1997; see the XML header).
- **URLs:** transliteration https://etcsl.orinst.ox.ac.uk/cgi-bin/etcsl.cgi?text=c.5.3.5 ; translation https://etcsl.orinst.ox.ac.uk/cgi-bin/etcsl.cgi?text=t.5.3.5 ; ORACC: catalogue Q000764 only (**no corpusjson** in the 2022 epsd2-literary export).
- **Retrieved:** 2026-10-19, copied from the local OTA 2518 bulk corpus (`../_bulk/etcsl-unzipped/etcsl/`). The XML is authoritative.
- **Licence:** CC BY-NC-SA 3.0 (OTA deposit); © ETCSL project, University of Oxford. Committed.

Content

Cosmogonic prologue (1–20: when An and Enlil had fixed the plans of heaven and earth, Enki organizes the rivers, marshes, sheepfolds, cities and kingship; he fills the marsh with fish and birds and assigns them their places); the quarrel (21–45A: Fish insults Bird first); Bird's reply and boasts (46–?); the alternation of speeches and acts (Fish destroys Bird's nest and young; Bird takes revenge, seizes Fish); the case before Enki; Enki's verdict for **Bird** (Bird is to be in the Ekur, its voice sweet to Enlil's ear); the colophon 188–190 "debate between Fish and Bird … because Bird was superior to Fish: praise be to Father Enki".

Files

- `c.5.3.5.xml`, `t.5.3.5.xml` — ETCSL TEI source (lemmatised `<w form lemma pos label>`).
- `transliteration.md` (189 composite lines: 1–178, 180, 182–190, with 45A; 179 and 181 are counted gaps), `translation.md` — conversions by `../../../tools/etcsl2md.py`.

Manuscripts

23 OB tablets and fragments (Nippur N/Ni/CBS/3N-T, Ur UET 6 38–41 and *394/*472, Isin IB 1127, VAT 6977+, AO 5396, BM 65147+, NBC 7912): list in the XML header. Nine lines carry manuscript variants ("1 ms. has instead/adds").

Line numbering

ETCSL composite numbering (1–190; one letter line 45A). Older literature (Vanstiphout 1997, COS 1.182? / Kramer 1964) may number differently: align by content.

Modern editions not used (recorded)

- Vanstiphout & Alster, composite + score (electronic, 1997; the basis of ETCSL); Vanstiphout's translation in *COS* 1 (1997) 581–584 — paid, not obtained.
- **Mittermayer 2019**, *"Was sprach der eine zum anderen?" Argumentationsformen in den sumerischen Rangstreitgesprächen* (UAVA 15): **open access** (CC BY-NC-ND 4.0) but the OAPEN server answers scripts with an anti-bot challenge; see `../../_records-only--Mittermayer-2019--Rangstreitgespraeche/`.

Usefulness

Base text (rank 1) for `סיפורי-הבריאה-המסופוטמיים/3-הציפור-והדג/`. Lemmas: ETCSL's TEI (`tools/sumerian_workbench.py lemmas|line`), morph from parsed instances elsewhere in ORACC (`… morph`). ETCSL's prose translation is rank 3 (check only, after drafting).